

PART 5: THE ENCOUNTER

Encounters in the wilderness are handled much the same as those in a dungeon. The main difference is that there is a chance of becoming lost, greater distances are involved, and there are special **evasion** procedures. The DM must also decide at what time during the day the encounter takes place, as this might indicate what type of terrain the party is moving through (and thus the kind of monsters that can be encountered). Most encounters will take place about midday or in the evening after the party has made camp. Encounters at night will require light sources for the party to effectively resolve the encounter.

TIME AND DISTANCE IN ENCOUNTERS. As in the D&D Basic rules, time in encounters is measured in 10-second rounds. Distances in the wilderness are measured in yards rather than feet. All movement and ranges are **tripled** (the area affected by a spell is not changed however). For example, an unencumbered man can move 120 yards per round; and a fire ball can reach a target 240 yards (720' away), affecting an area 40' in diameter.

Order of Events in One Game Day

1. The party decides their direction of travel.
2. The DM checks to see if the party becomes lost (1d6, see p. X56).
3. The DM rolls for wandering monsters (1d6, see p. X55).
4. If monsters are not encountered, the day ends. If monsters are encountered, the DM must determine the type of monsters and for the Number Appearing.
5. The DM rolls to check the distance between the monsters and the party (4d6).
6. The DM rolls to check surprise (1d6).
7. The DM and the party roll for initiative (1d6).
8. The DM rolls for Monster Reaction (2d6, see **Monster Reactions**).
9. The party and the monsters react. (If **Combat** occurs, see p. X23).
10. End of turn. When necessary, the DM should check the character's remaining hit points, changes in the party's marching order, and the duration of any spells in progress.

NUMBER APPEARING. Sometimes the number of monsters encountered will be decided by the design of the wilderness. Otherwise, a suggested range for the number of monsters is given with the monster description (as **No. Appearing**). The number given in the parentheses should be used for wilderness encounters. The DM should always take party strength into account when deciding how many monsters will appear.

DISTANCE. Encounters in the wilderness take place at much longer distances than in a dungeon. The distance may depend on local terrain; a monster seen coming out of a ravine that is only 20 yards away is encountered at that distance. If uncertain how far away the monster is, roll 4d6 and multiply the result by 10. This number (40-240) is the distance **in yards** at which the monster is first encountered.

SURPRISE. Surprise is handled the same as in the D&D Basic set, except that if either group is surprised the encounter distance between them will be 10-40 yards. The side which surprises gains one free round of action, while the surprised side can do nothing that round. If three or more creatures surprise a party, they may have moved into a circle around the party.

INITIATIVE. Each round of combat should begin by determining which side has the initiative and will act first. To determine initiative, each side rolls 1d6 (the DM rolls for the monsters). The side with the higher roll may move first and attack first in combat for that round. If both sides roll the same number, the DM may either demand that both sides roll again, or may consider movement and combat to occur at the same time for both sides (known as **simultaneous** combat).

Both sides should roll for initiative *each* round. If both sides tie on their initiative rolls, and combat is simultaneous, it is possible for both sides to be killed!

MONSTER REACTIONS. If the DM does not have the monster reactions planned in advance, the Monster Reaction table can be used to decide monster actions (roll 2d6 on the table below).

Monster Reactions

Dice Roll	Reaction
2	Immediate attack
3-5	Hostile, possible attack
6-8	Uncertain, monster confused
9-11	No attack, monster leaves
12	Enthusiastic friendship

EVASION. In the wilderness, parties with surprise may always avoid an encounter if desired. If the party does not surprise and still seeks to avoid an encounter the **evasion table** is used. Compare the size of the party to the number of creatures encountered. This gives the percentage chance the evasion will be successful. If a large party breaks up into small parties, roll for each small party separately. There is always at least a 5% chance of evasion unless surprised.

Evasion Table

	Party Size				Chance of Evasion
	1-4	5-12	13-24	25 +	
Number of Creatures Encountered	—	—	—	1-10	10%
	—	—	1-6	11-30	25%
	—	1-3	7-16	31+	35%
	1	4-8	17+	—	50%
	2-3	9+	—	—	70%
	4+	—	—	—	90%

The DM may adjust evasion chances for relative speed, terrain, and other factors as desired. For example, woods might add 25% to evasion chances and give a 10% chance for evasion even if a party is surprised. If one group can move at least twice as fast as the other, the faster group may increase (or decrease) the chances of evasion by 25% in its favor.

Though it might seem strange that it is easier to evade larger groups of opponents, the explanation is simple. A large group of creatures makes much more noise and is easier to identify (and avoid) than a small group. Also, if a large group remains together, they must travel at the speed of the slowest member. If the large group sends out small parties to scout or pursue, these will be more difficult to evade.